Annexation (Manifest Destiny)

John L. O'Sullivan · United States Magazine and Democratic Review · July–August 1845

Source: John L. O'Sullivan, 'Annexation,' United States Magazine and Democratic Review (July–Aug. 1845), text via Teaching American History. Public domain.

Editor John L. O'Sullivan coined the phrase 'manifest destiny' in this essay arguing for the annexation of Texas. The phrase captured a popular belief that the United States was providentially destined to expand across the continent — a belief used to justify the Mexican-American War, the displacement of Native peoples, and the expansion (or restriction) of slavery into new territories.

> *Connect: The Missouri Compromise (Class 8) tried to freeze the slavery question by geographic line. How does westward expansion re-open that wound?*

Key Passages

The famous phrase

> other nations have undertaken to intrude themselves into it, between us and the proper parties to the case … for the avowed object of thwarting our policy and hampering our power, limiting our greatness and checking the fulfillment of our manifest destiny to overspread the continent allotted by Providence for the free development of our yearly multiplying millions.

On California

> California will, probably, next fall away from the loose adhesion which, in such a country as Mexico, holds a remote province in a slight equivocal kind of dependence on the metropolis. … Imbecile and distracted, Mexico never can exert any real governmental authority over such a country.

On race and 'progress'

> The Anglo-Saxon foot is already on its borders. Already the advance guard of the irresistible army of Anglo-Saxon emigration has begun to pour down upon it, armed with the plow and the rifle, and marking its trail with schools and colleges, courts and representative halls, mills and meeting-houses.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	Debate over annexing Texas (annexed 1845), the Oregon boundary dispute with Britain, and growing tensions with Mexico on the eve of the Mexican-American War.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Readers of the Democratic Review, mostly Democrats and supporters of expansion, and the wider reading public.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	John L. O'Sullivan, a Democratic editor and nationalist who saw American expansion as God's plan; Mexican and Native views are absent.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ: Identify ONE specific U.S. policy that translated the rhetoric of ‘manifest destiny’ into action between 1845 and 1860.
2. How does O’Sullivan’s racial framing shape the argument? What groups does it exclude?
3. Why did this phrase, coined in a magazine essay, become so politically powerful?

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> Defending the annexation of Texas, O'Sullivan coined the era's rallying cry: it was America's “manifest destiny to overspread the continent,” a Providence-given right that justified westward expansion to the Pacific.

Texas is now ours

It is now time for the opposition to the Annexation of Texas to cease, all further agitation of the waters of bitterness and strife, at least in connection with this question—even though it may perhaps be required of us as a necessary condition of the freedom of our institutions, that we must live on forever in a state of unpausing struggle and excitement upon some subject of party division or other. But, in regard to Texas, enough has now been given to party. It is time for the common duty of patriotism to the country to succeed;—or if this claim will not be recognized, it is at least time for common sense to acquiesce with decent grace in the inevitable and the irrevocable. . . . Texas is now ours. . . . She is no longer to us a mere geographical space—a certain combination of coast, plain, mountain, valley, forest, and stream. She is no longer to us a mere country on the map. . . . It is time then that all should cease to treat her as alien, and even adverse—cease to denounce and vilify all and everything connected with her accession—cease to thwart and oppose the remaining steps for its consummation; or where such efforts are felt to be unavailing, at least to embitter the hour of reception by all the most ungracious frowns of aversion and words of unwelcome. There has been enough of all this.

[. . .]

The famous phrase

Why, were other reasoning wanting, in favor of now elevating this question of the reception of Texas into the Union, out of the lower region of our past party dissensions, up to its proper level of a high and broad nationality, it surely is to be found, found abundantly, in the manner in which other nations have undertaken to intrude themselves into it, between us and the proper parties to the case, in a spirit of hostile interference against us, for the avowed object of thwarting our policy and hampering our power, limiting our greatness and checking the fulfillment of our manifest destiny to overspread the continent allotted by Providence for the free development of our yearly multiplying millions. . . . This we have seen done by England, our old rival and enemy; and by France, strangely coupled with her against us,

[. . .]

On slavery and race

Nor is there any just foundation for the charge that annexation is a great proslavery measure—calculated to increase and perpetuate that institution. Slavery had nothing to do with it. . . . The greater value in Texas of the slave labor now employed in those states must soon produce the effect of draining off that labor southwardly, by the same unvarying law that bids water descend the slope that invites it.

[. . .]

On California

California will, probably, next fall away from the loose adhesion which, in such a country as Mexico, holds a remote province in a slight equivocal kind of dependence on the metropolis. Imbecile and distracted, Mexico never can exert any real governmental authority over such a country. . . . In the case of California this is now impossible. The Anglo-Saxon foot is already on its borders. Already the advance guard of the irresistible army of Anglo-Saxon emigration has begun to pour down upon it, armed with the plow and the rifle, and marking its trail with schools and colleges, courts and representative

halls, mills and meeting-houses. A population will soon be in actual occupation of California, over which it will be idle for Mexico to dream of dominion. They will necessarily become independent. . . . And they will have a right to independence—to self-government—to the possession of the homes conquered from the wilderness by their own labors and dangers, sufferings and sacrifices—a better and a truer right than the artificial tide of sovereignty in Mexico, a thousand miles distant, inheriting from Spain a title good only against those who have none better.

[. . .]

Away, then, with all idle French talk of balances of power on the American continent. There is no growth in Spanish America! . . . And whosoever may hold the balance, though they should cast into the opposite scale all the bayonets and cannon, not only of France and England, but of Europe entire, how would it kick the beam against the simple, solid weight of the two hundred and fifty, or three hundred millions—and American millions—destined to gather beneath the flutter of the stripes and stars, in the fast hastening year of the Lord 1945!

Words to know

acquiesce — accept something without protest

consummation — the final completing step of a process

manifest destiny — the belief that America was obviously meant to spread across the continent

Providence — God’s guiding plan

Anglo-Saxon — white, English-descended Americans, here claimed as a superior people

metropolis — the ruling home country of a distant province

balances of power — European idea that no single nation should grow too strong